

One Region, Two Windows

Lesson 5 — Comparing across regional in-depth topics

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain why comparing our two topics helps even though the exam tests them separately

2

Preview the essential shape of both regional in-depth topics ahead

3

Identify likely points of comparison to watch for as we go deeper into each

4

Close Block A with every foundational Paper 3 skill in place

Four lessons, one complete toolkit

Command terms, essay structure, historiography, and evaluation — the full skill set this course will apply, in depth, to two very different corners of the same region. Today previews both, before we go deep into each in turn.

The exam is separate; your understanding shouldn't be

You will never be asked to write one essay spanning both topics — each essay stays within its own regional in-depth topic. But seeing genuine patterns across both deepens your grasp of each individually, and equips you to write more sophisticated, historically aware essays on either one alone.

The Middle East, and African independence

MIDDLE EAST, C. 1945–2020

- Arab nationalism and the legacy of colonial-era border-drawing
- The Arab-Israeli conflict, from 1948 to the Oslo era and beyond
- The 1979 Iranian Revolution and its regional aftershocks
- Shifting foreign relations: Cold War rivalry, then post-2001 dynamics

INDEPENDENCE MOVEMENTS, C. 1900–2000

- Algeria — a long, violent war against French rule, ending 1962
- Angola and Guinea — armed liberation struggles against Portugal
- Ghana — a comparatively rapid, largely negotiated path, 1957
- Namibia and Tanganyika — mandate-era and Cold-War-shaped routes to independence

Colonial power shapes the path to independence

France, Britain, and Portugal each governed differently, and each responded differently once independence movements grew: Portugal's Estado Novo regime refused negotiation almost everywhere, producing prolonged armed conflict in Angola and Guinea; Britain, especially after 1957's Ghana precedent, increasingly favoured negotiated transition. Watch for this pattern as we build out both topics in depth.

External great-power rivalry, in both regions

Cold War competition between the United States and Soviet Union shaped outcomes in both topics — arming and funding different sides in Angola's independence and civil conflict, just as it shaped alliances and rivalries across the Middle East. Neither region's history in this period can be fully explained without this external dimension.

Borders drawn from outside, with different consequences

Arbitrary colonial-era borders shaped instability in both regions, but differently: in the Middle East, they cut across religious, ethnic, and tribal lines in ways still driving conflict; in several of our African cases, similar arbitrary borders combined with Cold War-era proxy conflict to produce prolonged civil wars after independence itself, not only before it.

Comparison is not equivalence

Six different African independence movements are not interchangeable with each other, let alone with the Middle East's very different trajectory. Use comparison to sharpen your understanding of what is genuinely distinctive in each case — never to flatten them into one generic “decolonization story”.

Predicting patterns

Based on today's preview alone, write down two specific predictions about what you expect to find as we study both topics in depth — you will check these against what we actually learn.

- One prediction about a similarity between the two topics
- One prediction about a genuine difference between them
- One sentence on what evidence would prove your prediction wrong

Key terms from today

Estado Novo

Portugal's authoritarian regime, notably resistant to decolonization.

Arbitrary borders

Colonial-era boundaries drawn without regard to existing ethnic or religious lines.

Proxy conflict

A conflict shaped by external powers backing opposing local sides.

Comparative sharpening

Using comparison to clarify what's distinctive in each case, not to flatten differences.

Every foundational skill now in place

Command terms, essay structure, historiography, evaluation, and now a first comparative preview of both regional in-depth topics. Every lesson from here goes deep into actual content — starting with the Middle East.

Lesson 6 — The Middle East after 1945: the regional picture

Next lesson starts Block B: the region as it actually looked at the end of the Second World War, before Arab nationalism, Israel, or the Cold War reshaped it entirely.